

DIGITAL GUIDE

The SG Recruiter Translation Guide

How to turn a resume built for your home market into one a Singapore recruiter reads as instantly credible — currency, titles, and framing, done right.

FOR CANDIDATES FROM MALAYSIA · TAIWAN · HONG KONG · INDONESIA · THE PHILIPPINES · THAILAND

Quick-Start Checklist

Work through this in order. Each item is explained in full further in the guide — use this page as your at-a-glance summary.

- ☐ Convert achievement/revenue figures (deal size, portfolio value) to SGD using the current mid-market rate, rounded and labeled "approx."
- ☐ Do **not** put salary history on your resume or LinkedIn — leave it off entirely.
- ☐ For application-form salary fields or recruiter calls, use market-percentile framing instead of a bare SGD conversion.
- ☐ Convert your job title using the table for your home market.
- ☐ Add a study/work time-split line if you studied and worked in different markets.
- ☐ Run the 6-point recruiter scan checklist against your draft.
- ☐ Rewrite your LinkedIn headline using one of the four formulas.
- ☐ Write your cover letter using the formula, not a fill-in template.
- ☐ Check formatting — no tables/text boxes over your name, title, dates, or contact info.

Why This Guide Exists

A Singapore recruiter spends roughly 6–8 seconds on first pass. In that window, they're not reading your resume — they're pattern-matching it against resumes they already understand. If your salary is in the wrong currency, your job title doesn't map to anything they recognize, or your work history reads "foreign" instead of "regional," you get filtered before anyone reads a single bullet point.

This guide converts your resume from *"built for my home market"* to *"instantly legible to an SG hiring manager"* — without erasing what makes your regional experience valuable.

Part 1: Currency Conversion — Achievements vs. Salary Are Not the Same Problem

These two use different logic, and mixing them up is exactly what makes a resume look off to an SG recruiter. Treat them separately.

1A. Achievement & revenue figures — convert directly, always

Deal sizes, revenue managed, shipment values, portfolio values — these are **market-priced**. A TWD 8M shipment is worth roughly the same in real terms whether it's booked out of Taipei or Singapore; freight rates, cargo values, and B2B contract sizes don't move with local cost-of-living the way wages do. So direct FX conversion here is accurate, not misleading — keep doing it.

Format to use on your resume/LinkedIn:

"Managed accounts generating [local currency] X, equivalent to approx. SGD Y"

The method (rates move — do this at time of writing):

1. Look up the current mid-market rate (XE.com or Google "X to SGD") — not a bank rate, those are padded
2. Round to a clean number — SGD 320,000, not SGD 319,847. Recruiters remember round numbers, not precise ones
3. Label it "approx." or "~" — this reads as market-aware, not sloppy
4. Refresh the conversion every few months, especially for MYR, IDR, and PHP, where drift against SGD is larger

Example: "Managed a portfolio of 12 enterprise accounts generating TWD 8M in annual revenue (approx. SGD 320,000)"

1B. Salary figures — don't convert directly, use market-context instead

First, where this applies: not on the resume itself. Don't include salary history on your resume or LinkedIn — it invites recruiters to anchor an offer low before you've had a real conversation about scope, and the resume's job is to get you the interview, not negotiate the offer. This section is for the two places salary actually comes up:

- **Application form fields** that require "current/last drawn salary" (common on SG job portals, including MyCareersFuture)
- **Recruiter screening calls**, where it's often an early question

This is the case most guides get wrong. Salary reflects local wage structures and cost of living, not a market-priced transaction — so a strong Taiwan starting salary like TWD 45,000 converts to a *weak-looking* SGD 1,800 that misrepresents your actual standing. Converting it directly doesn't inform the recruiter, it understates you.

The fix: don't lead with a converted salary number at all. If a salary figure is unavoidable, use market-percentile framing instead of a bare converted figure:

"TWD 45,000 starting salary — top 20% of entry-level logistics salaries in the Taiwan market (source: 104 Job Bank salary benchmark)"

This tells the recruiter what the number *means* locally, rather than asking them to silently (and incorrectly) benchmark it against SGD norms.

Local salary-benchmark sources, by market:

Home market	Benchmark source
Taiwan	104 Job Bank salary reports, 1111 Job Bank
Malaysia	JobStreet Malaysia salary guide
Hong Kong	JobsDB Hong Kong, Michael Page HK salary guide
Indonesia	JobStreet Indonesia, Kalibrr salary insights
Philippines	JobStreet Philippines, Kalibrr
Thailand	JobsDB Thailand, Adecco Thailand salary guide

One more distinction worth making explicit: past salary (home-market currency and context) and your SG salary *expectation* are two different numbers. Don't derive your SG ask by converting your old salary — anchor your SG expectation to the SG market rate for the role and level you're applying to (MyCareersFuture salary data or Glassdoor SG listings). Converting backward from a lower-cost-of-living salary will anchor your negotiation low.

Part 2: Job Title Conversion Tables

Home-market titles often carry inflated or unclear seniority signals. Use the SG-equivalent column on your resume header/summary; keep your original title in the role details.

Malaysia

Your title	SG-equivalent framing
Executive	Associate / Specialist
Senior Executive	Senior Associate / Analyst
Assistant Manager	Assistant Manager (direct match — safe to keep)
Manager	Manager (direct match, but confirm team size in bullets)

Taiwan

Many Japanese-affiliated firms in Taiwan (freight forwarding, trading houses, manufacturing) use a Japanese-style rank ladder rather than the generic 專員/副理/經理 titles. If you worked under this system, use this table instead — it's more precise and signals the right seniority level.

Your title	Literal role	SG-equivalent framing
課員 (kèyuán)	Rank-and-file staff	Associate
主任 (zhǔrèn)	Supervisor / senior staff	Senior Associate / Team Lead
副課長 (fù kèzhǎng)	Deputy Section Chief	Assistant Manager
課長 (kèzhǎng)	Section Chief	Manager
次長 (cìzhǎng)	Deputy Department Head	Senior Manager
部長 (bùzhǎng)	Department Head	Director / Head of Department

If your company used the generic titles instead (專員/副理/經理), use this simpler mapping:

Your title	SG-equivalent framing
專員 (Specialist)	Associate / Specialist
副理 (Deputy Manager)	Assistant Manager
經理 (Manager)	Manager

業務代表 (Sales Representative)

Business Development Representative / Account Executive

Hong Kong

Your title	SG-equivalent framing
Officer	Associate / Analyst
Senior Officer	Senior Associate
Assistant Vice President (AVP)	Manager / Senior Manager (AVP titles inflate in SG context — reframe by scope, not title)
Relationship Manager	Relationship Manager (direct match)

Indonesia

Your title	SG-equivalent framing
Staff	Associate / Analyst
Supervisor	Team Lead / Senior Associate
Asisten Manajer	Assistant Manager
Manajer	Manager

Philippines

Your title	SG-equivalent framing
Associate (BPO/shared-services)	Associate — add a scope clarifier, e.g. "Associate, [function]," since "Associate" alone reads as entry-level BPO in SG
Team Lead	Team Lead / Assistant Manager depending on team size
Supervisor	Assistant Manager
Account Executive (sales)	Account Executive (direct match — safe to keep)

Thailand

Your title	SG-equivalent framing
เจ้าหน้าที่ (Officer)	Associate / Analyst

หัวหน้างาน (Supervisor)	Team Lead / Senior Associate
ผู้ช่วยผู้จัดการ (Assistant Manager)	Assistant Manager (direct match)
ผู้จัดการ (Manager)	Manager

Part 3: Framing Study-Then-Work Timelines

If you studied in one market and worked in another (or studied abroad before returning home), don't let the gap look unexplained. Use a simple time-split framing in your resume summary or LinkedIn About:

"4 years studying in [country], 2 years working in [country/market]"

This does two things: it pre-answers the recruiter's silent question ("why the gap/why here"), and it signals adaptability across markets — a real asset for SG roles with regional scope. Adjust the split to your own timeline; the format is what matters, not the specific numbers.

Part 4: What SG Recruiters Scan For First

Run your resume against this in order — this is the actual scan sequence, not a random checklist.

1. **Current location / work eligibility status** — stated clearly near the top, not buried
2. **Most recent title + company**, in terms an SG reader recognizes (use your Part 2 conversion)
3. **Salary/scope signal** — SGD-converted figures or team size, in the first or second bullet of your most recent role
4. **Regional scope** — if you've worked across markets, say so explicitly ("managed accounts across Malaysia, Taiwan, and Singapore") — this is a differentiator, don't bury it
5. **Language stack** — list languages with proficiency level, not just "Multilingual" — SG employers with regional accounts specifically screen for this
6. **Formatting sanity check** — no tables/text boxes over the parsing-critical zones (name, title, dates, contact) — this is what breaks ATS parsing even on visually nice templates

Part 5: LinkedIn Headline Formulas (Regional → SG)

Fill in the brackets — don't copy verbatim, ATS/recruiter search penalizes identical boilerplate across many profiles.

1. [Function] professional | [X] years in [market] | Targeting [Singapore/APAC] roles in [industry]
2. [Current title] at [current company] | [Language 1, Language 2, Language 3] | Open to Singapore relocation
3. Helping [client type] with [core skill] across [Market A, Market B] | Now based in Singapore
4. [Industry] specialist | [Home market] → Singapore | [Key achievement in 4–6 words]

Part 6: Cover Letter Framework (Not a Template)

A fill-in template reads as AI-generated boilerplate the moment two buyers use it. Use this as a formula instead:

- **Line 1:** Name the specific role and one concrete reason you're targeting *this* company (not "I am excited to apply")
- **Line 2–3:** One achievement from your resume, stated with a number — but explain what it *means* in SG market terms (don't just repeat the resume line)
- **Line 4:** Directly address the regional-to-SG transition in one sentence — don't let the recruiter wonder about it silently
- **Line 5:** A specific, low-friction call to action ("happy to share more detail on a short call this week")